

Irish Defence at a Glance: Q2 2026

Quick-reference figures on Irish defence spending, personnel, fleets, and operations. Every figure dated and sourced.

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€1.49bn DEFENCE BUDGET 2026 Record allocation · +11% on 2025	7,756 PERSONNEL (END-2025) vs establishment of 9,739	~0.3% OF GDP ON DEFENCE Lowest in EU · EU avg est. 2.1% (2025)	8 ships NAVAL VESSELS Typically ~4 in operational rotation
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1. Budget and Spending — Budget 2026, announced October 2025

Defence Vote Group 2026	€1.49 billion — a record allocation, up €145m (11%) on 2025 and €383m (35%) since 2022
Capital allocation 2026	€300 million — the highest ever, up 40% year on year
NDP capital 2026–2030	€1.7 billion, a 55% increase on the previous €1.1 billion baseline
Current spending 2026	€873 million, including €485m for Permanent Defence Force pay and provision for a net 400 additional recruits
Government commitment	Defence funding of €1.5 billion (at January 2022 prices) by 2028 under Level of Ambition 2
Share of GDP	Approximately 0.3% — the lowest in the EU. EU average: 1.9% of GDP in 2024; estimated 2.1% in 2025 (EDA)

Sources: Department of Defence / gov.ie, Budget 2026 (Oct 2025); National Development Plan (Jul 2025); European Defence Agency, Defence Data 2024–2025 (Sep 2025).

2. Personnel Strength — Official end-2025 figures

Permanent Defence Force	7,756 at end-2025, against an establishment of 9,739 — a shortfall of roughly 2,000
By service	Army 6,184 · Naval Service 807 · Air Corps 765
Trend	Net growth of roughly 200 in 2025 — the strongest year since the post-2020 decline; Naval Service +115 net was the largest gain of the three services. Strength had fallen to ~7,500 in 2023–24.
Recruitment pipeline	Applications up 30% in 2024 and more than 30% again year on year to September 2025; Budget 2026 funds a net +400 per year
Reserve Defence Force	1,811 effective personnel against an establishment of 4,069
LOA 2 target	11,500 permanent personnel by 2028 — a target the Government has acknowledged will be ‘without question... challenging’ to meet (Dáil, Feb 2025)

Sources: Department of Defence end-2025 strength return (reported Feb 2026); Dáil and written-answer record (Feb–Nov 2025); Commission on the Defence Forces (2022).

3. Naval Service and Maritime — Fleet status as of November 2025

Fleet — 8 vessels	4 Samuel Beckett-class OPVs (P61–P64, commissioned 2014–2019) · 2 Róisín-class (P51–P52, in reserve) · 2 Lake-class inshore patrol vessels (ex-RNZN, acquired 2023): LÉ Aoibhinn operational, LÉ Gobnait not yet operational
Operational availability	Typically around four vessels in the operational rotation (three P60s plus LÉ Aoibhinn as of November 2025)
Maritime domain	880,000 km ² of maritime zone — roughly ten times Ireland’s land area and one of the largest in Europe
Capability programmes	Towed-array sonar and the Subsea Awareness programme funded in Budget 2026; National Maritime Security Strategy 2026–2030 published February 2026 (six strategic objectives)
Gaps	Vessels not armed for combat; no anti-submarine weapons capability; no standing subsea cable monitoring

Sources: Naval Service fleet records (Nov 2025); Budget 2026; National Maritime Security Strategy (Feb 2026).

4. Air Corps — Fleet as of Q1 2026

Maritime patrol	2 × Airbus C295W MSA (delivered 2023)
Transport / utility	1 × C295W transport (Oct 2025, completing the €300m C295 programme) · 4 × Pilatus PC-12NG (3 ISTAR, 1 utility) · 1 × Falcon 6X (delivered 2025, replacing the Learjet 45)
Helicopters / trainers	6 × AW139 · 2 × EC135 P2 · 8 × PC-9M (armable trainers). On order: 4 × Airbus H145M (€91.7m, ordered late 2024) — three by end-2027, the fourth in early 2028
Programmes	Military Radar Programme: phased rollout from 2026, full delivery by 2028, including maritime ship-borne radar · Counter-drone capability: €19m accelerated programme, delivery targeted summer–September 2026 ahead of the EU Presidency
Gaps	No fighter or air-intercept aircraft and no surface-to-air capability; unknown aircraft in Irish airspace are intercepted by the RAF under an unpublished arrangement
Ahead	To be renamed the Irish Air Force from 2027 under CoDF reforms; AW139s planned for replacement by eight medium-lift helicopters

Sources: Updated Detailed Implementation Plan (Feb 2026); Department of Defence; Air Corps fleet records (Q1 2026).

5. Overseas Operations — As of May 2026

UNIFIL (Lebanon)	~340–360 personnel, Irish/Polish Battalion. Final mandate to 31 December 2026, withdrawal during 2027 (Government decision, May 2026). Ireland’s longest mission: 30,000+ served since 1978.
Other commitments	UNTSO observer postings continue; the UNDOF (Golan Heights) contingent was withdrawn in April 2024.
After UNIFIL	No major formed-unit mission remains once UNIFIL closes — a first since 1978

Sources: gov.ie, Government decision on UNIFIL (May 2026); UN Security Council resolution (Aug 2025); Oireachtas record.

6. Transformation and European Frameworks — As of June 2026

CoDF implementation	54 of 130 recommendations complete as of 31 December 2025; Updated Detailed Implementation Plan and Strategic Framework for Transformation published 10 February 2026; remaining 76 scheduled out to 2028 and beyond
PESCO	Full participant in 6 projects (Dáil approvals to July 2024, incl. Critical Seabed Infrastructure Protection and the Network of Logistic Hubs), observer on 17; concentrated in maritime, cyber and logistics. 75 PESCO projects exist EU-wide since May 2025.
SAFE (€150bn)	Ireland declined loans (Sept 2025) but joined the joint-procurement strand; 16 states' allocations approved (Jan 2026), first agreements signed (May 2026). Minister for Defence (Feb 2026): Ireland should participate if the window reopens.
UK–Ireland	Refreshed Defence MoU signed at the Cork Summit, 13 March 2026 (previous: 2015), plus a Subsea Infrastructure Bilateral Collaboration Framework; first live exercise September 2026
Other 2026 milestones	France preferred partner, Armoured Fleet Programme (Feb 2026) · Defence attaché pilot: London, Paris, Washington · Critical Entities Resilience Strategy published 12 February 2026

Sources: gov.ie (Feb–May 2026); Dáil motion on PESCO participation (Jun–Jul 2024); EU Council/Commission SAFE records; UK Government, Cork Summit joint statement (13 Mar 2026).

ABOUT THIS DATA SHEET

Every figure carries the date it refers to, and every section names its sources. Personnel figures are the official end-2025 strength return, the latest annual data; budget figures are the Budget 2026 allocations as announced. This edition supersedes the Q1 2026 data sheet, which has been withdrawn. Corrections and queries: info@securityireland.ie.